

FREE SAMPLE

Ball Python Care Package

The first 5 pages of the 49-page printable manual, free to keep.



In this sample: What's inside, How to Use This Package, Quick Profile & Cost Overview, The Species, Morphs, Size & Lifespan. The contents page shows every one of the 49 pages, so you can see exactly what the full package covers before you buy it.

Not in this sample: the 44 pages that follow, which are the full care guide, the health section, the quick reference cards, and the owner tools, checklists and logs.

The full package is \$8.99 at beastlyfacts.com/care-packages/ball-python/. One purchase, and every corrected edition is a free re-download from your library. The free ball python care guide it was built from is at beastlyfacts.com/guides/ball-python/, and stays free.

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What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice. Temperatures appear in degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C) beside them. Sizes appear in inches (in) and feet (ft), with centimeters (cm) beside them. A snake and its weight log are measured in grams (g), the unit a kitchen scale shows. Humidity is a percentage (%) of the moisture the air could hold. Prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't set up yet

Check the law first, on page 24: a ball python is legal without a permit in most of the United States, but not everywhere. Then read pages 4 to 11 in order before buying anything. Enclosure material, heat control and humidity are the three decisions that are expensive to redo, and the three most often chosen wrong. Get them right the first time, and use the Budget & Shopping List on page 34 to buy once.

If your ball python is already home

Audit what you have against the Setup Checklist in the print list below, and go to the Red Flags page (page 25) if anything seems off. If the problem is a snake that won't eat, start on page 15 instead: refusal is common in this species and usually normal. If any heat source is running without a thermostat, fix that today, before anything else on this list.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Page 32: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 40: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 33: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 41: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 37: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 42: Equipment, Quarantine & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 38: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 43: Enrichment Checklist & Log |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Ball python keeping has moved a long way from the small-tub advice that dominated it for years. This package reflects current enclosure-size, humidity and enrichment standards, including the housing study on page 19, cross-checked against the veterinary and scientific sources listed on page 46.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A reptile-experienced veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is always a vet call, not a page in this book. Find a reptile vet before you need one and write the number on the emergency card. Nothing on the law page is legal advice either.

SECTION 01 · PROFILE

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Python regius</i> , called the royal python in Europe
Adult size	3 to 5 ft (90 to 150 cm); females significantly larger than males
Captive lifespan	20 to 30 years with good care, and some live far longer. About 10 years on average in the wild
Native range	Grassland, open forest and farmland across West and Central Africa, from Senegal to Uganda
Diet type	Carnivore: whole frozen-thawed mice and rats, one meal every 5 to 14 days depending on age (page 12)
Enclosure minimum (adult)	4×2×2 ft (120×60×60 cm, roughly 120 gallons), at least as long as the snake. PVC (polyvinyl chloride, a rigid plastic) preferred over glass
Humidity	55 to 65%, raised to 70 to 80% through a shed (page 9)
The one hard rule	Every heat source runs through a thermostat. No exceptions (page 8)
Sexual maturity	Males from about 16 to 18 months; females from about 27 to 31 months, at around 1,500 g (page 22)
Handling difficulty	Beginner to intermediate. Defensive as a juvenile, generally mellow as a settled adult
Conservation	Near Threatened on the International Union for Conservation of Nature Red List, pressured by collection and export for the pet trade and by habitat loss

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$40 to \$100 for a standard snake, \$510 to \$1,245 for the equipment, plus \$50 to \$150 for the first vet exam: \$560 to \$1,395 before the snake. Every line is on page 34.

Yearly ongoing

\$290 to \$635 a year, about \$20 to \$55 a month, for frozen rodents, substrate, electricity, two UVB tubes a year if you run one, and the yearly vet exam.

BUDGET FOR THE WORST CASE TOO

A sick or emergency visit runs \$100 to \$500 or more, and imaging or surgery pushes that higher. Neither is likely if you follow this package, but an animal that lives 20 to 30 years will need a vet at some point. Set the money aside now rather than deciding in an emergency.

Fun facts worth knowing

- The name comes from the defensive pose, not the diet. A stressed ball python curls into a tight ball with its head tucked in the center, so a new snake that won't uncurl isn't being difficult. It just hasn't decided yet that hiding is unnecessary.
- It hunts with heat. Pits along the upper lip detect the body warmth of nearby prey, letting a ball python strike accurately in total darkness.
- A brooding female coils around her eggs without warming them. Brashears and DeNardo (2015) measured six python species at brooding temperatures and found no heat production in five, the ball python among them.

The species, morphs, size & lifespan

What you are buying, where it came from, how big it gets, and how long it stays.

One species

The ball python is *Python regius*, native to the grasslands, open forests and farmland of West and Central Africa. In the wild it eats small mammals, birds and amphibians, and it is an ambush predator that spends most of its life concealed, which is why cover matters so much in its enclosure. It is the most popular pet snake in the world.

Where pet ball pythons come from

Almost the entire wild supply traces to three countries at the center of the range: Benin, Ghana and Togo, which have exported close to four million ball pythons since 1978, most of them to the United States. Snakes were taken straight from the wild through the 1980s and 1990s; since the early 2000s most exports have been ranched, meaning eggs and gravid (egg-carrying) females are collected from the wild and the hatchlings raised briefly and shipped. The species makes up roughly 80 percent of all snake exports under Appendix II of CITES, the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora, the treaty that tracks trade in species that could become threatened by it. The captive-bred hobby grew out of the 1990s, when the first albino ball pythons were bred.

Captive-bred snakes make the better pets: less likely to bite, more likely to accept the food offered, and less likely to carry parasites. Wild-caught and imported animals routinely carry much heavier parasite loads, and because the two get mixed at shows and in the trade, no seller's word replaces the fecal test on page 20.

Morphs, and what a price does not tell you

A morph is a selectively bred line with a different color or pattern. There are hundreds of them, combined into more than 7,000 recorded combinations. A standard snake runs \$40 to \$100, a common single-gene morph \$50 to \$150, and designer morphs \$250 to \$5,000 or more. One widely bred gene carries a known health cost: the spider morph is linked to wobble syndrome, a heritable neurological disorder that shows as side-to-side or twisting head movements, poor coordination, and trouble striking or constricting prey. Rose and Williams (2014) first described it from a survey of breeders and keepers, and Starck and colleagues (2022) found malformed balance organs in the inner ear of every spider morph they imaged. A spider, or any combination carrying the gene, may struggle to feed, and its offspring can inherit the condition. A wild-type, the natural pattern with no morph gene, or a single-gene morph with no known defect is the lower-risk first snake.

Size and lifespan

Growth	Hatchlings start at about a foot (30 cm) and reach roughly 3 ft (90 cm) by age three.
Adult length	3 to 5 ft (90 to 150 cm). Females are significantly larger than males.
Lifespan	20 to 30 years in captivity is common, against about 10 in the wild. Some live far longer: a zoo female laid eggs at 62 years old.

A ball python bought for a child can still be in the house when that child is grown. Plan for the whole span: the enclosure, the frozen rodents and a reptile vet for every one of those years.